it seems so easy, and today some people feel that any donkey can contest and win from that seat, that was not the case at that time. Because Bangalore South has a huge population of Vokkaligas who were not exactly BJP's pals at the time. Despite all this, Ananth Kumar won that seat six times, even though the caste balance of that constituency was not in favour of Brahmins. That is a good credit to him and the party.

'We were a Brahmin-based party,' says B.Y. Vijayendraa. 'But BSY identified other people in the coalition like C.J. Halnol, a Dalit leader, H.N. Nanjegowda for Vokkaligas. They were successfully roped into the BJP. We couldn't have got people of such stature earlier. A lot of Dalits moved into BJP due to this move. This was a big turning point for BJP in 1994–95. In earlier days, we were a Brahmin-dominated party and an urban party. We then expanded our base. Pre-2000, we were seen as a Lingayat and Brahmin party. Now, after the 2019 Lok Sabha elections, we are a Brahmin plus Lingayat plus Backward plus Vokkaliga party.'[93]

Growth did not come without battles over control, both within the state unit and between the state unit and the central leadership. During his first term as chief minister, there were allegations of corruption in mining contracts in Bellary against Yediyurappa,[94] which undermined the BJP's national campaign against corruption and caused deep intra-party tensions.[95] It led to Yediyurappa leaving the BJP in 2012 and fighting the 2013 elections as the head of a new regional party, the Karnataka Janata Paksh (KJP). Though his outfit won only six seats, it bagged a crucial 9.79 per cent of the vote share,[96] badly damaging the BJP, which plunged to its lowest tally in the state in two decades. This demonstrated Yediyurappa's personal influence in rural areas, leading to his return to the party in 2013.

While both Ananth Kumar and Yediyurappa expanded the party, their deep rivalry also set back some of the advances. 'Yediyurappa became leader of opposition in 1994. In 1996, Ananth became MP. From there, their differences started,' recalls Lehar Singh. 'Both started having a rivalry. This came to a peak in 2004 when Yediyurappa was not allowed to become Opposition leader for two